PRINCIPLE IV: AI-ASSISTED LANGUAGE EDUCATION SHOULD BE HUMAN-CENTRED

Guideline 7

Prepare learners for critical, healthy engagement with AI

About this guideline

Artificial intelligence is increasingly present in the lives of language learners, both inside and beyond the classroom, often without critical framing that would ensure its effective and safe use. This guideline examines how language education can provide learners with competences needed to engage with AI tools and AI output in a thoughtful, ethical and effective way. This involves developing AI literacy skills, ensuring learner well-being in learning environments where human and non-human input co-exist, and preserving the learners' identity, voice and plurilingual repertoire in spite of the dominant/standardised norms and content that LLMs tend to (re)produce.

Language education is well positioned to foster the competences that learners need to develop **AI literacy**, especially when working in traditions that foster critical literacy (Edge, 2006; Pennycook, 2010). Evaluating texts for accuracy, register, communicative and cultural appropriateness and ideological stance are some of the practices that are likely to exist in language learning curricula, and these can be readily leveraged to compare human- and AI-generated texts. Language teachers can rely on established disciplinary strengths to help learners understand how discourse is generated, and classroom work can extend the collaborative critique of hallucinations and embedded bias. Similarly, existing practices in teaching speaking and writing can be deployed to develop effective prompting strategies, and to interrogate, revise, and respond to AI output. Such activities can simultaneously function as language learning and AI literacy education.

To ensure **learner well-being**, teachers can take steps to calibrate AI-supported tasks and practice opportunities with authentic human interaction. Among other things, they can monitor for isolation, fatigue and disengagement associated with excessive screen time or AI overuse (Deep & Chen, 2025; Lepp et al., 2022; Zhang & Liu, 2025). An additional concern is that digital routines in the language classroom should remain age-appropriate and consistent with the learners' cognitive strengths and needs.

A third concern relates to **learner identity**, and the risk that this may be eroded by the increase in AI-supported practices. Language education has a long humanist tradition, with a commitment to voice, personal narrative and respect for diversity that can be usefully brought to bear here. For example, teachers may design AI-supported tasks that use learner experience and personal narrative as the starting point, treating AI-generated content as a foil or talking partner rather than a model, and inviting learners to compare, contest and personalise its output. Another possibility involves using AI-supported speaking and writing tasks in ways that preserve space for genuine authorial choice, by framing AI as a resource for drafting or editing rather than a source of finished text. Additionally, it is

possible to leverage the multilingual capabilities of AI to create space for dynamic cross-linguistic practice, using translation, comparison and code-switching as resources for meaning-making.

References

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Competences and reflection questions

7.1 I can use AI to support the development of (critical) literacy skills

Descriptor: *How well do I integrate language practice and AI literacy development in my teaching practice?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Which critical literacy practices in my current teaching can I readily transfer to the evaluation of AI-generated texts?
- How do I help learners critique AI-generated content, and what language learning opportunities does this create?
- What can I do to integrate AI literacy work in meaningful language learning activity rather than treat it as a separate technical skill?
- How might effective prompting be taught as a language learning activity (e.g., by connecting to existing work on register, genre, and communicative purpose)?

7.2 I can use AI to nurture learners' well-being

Descriptor: *How effectively do I preserve learner well-being in an AI-assisted environment?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- What signs of fatigue, disengagement, or over-reliance on AI do I look for during AI-supported activities? How do I respond when I notice them?
- How do I adapt AI-supported tasks to accommodate learners with different cognitive strengths, learning differences, or levels of digital confidence?
- What can I do to encourage learners to reflect on their own experience of AI-assisted learning, its effect on their well-being and possible over-dependence?

7.3 I can use AI to support the development of the learners' identity

Descriptor: *How well do the AI-assisted tasks that I design affirm learner identity?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- What are my teaching options, when AI-supported tasks appear to be producing uniform or formulaic output that overrides learner voice?
- In what ways do I invite learners to draw on their own experiences and perspectives to compare, contest, or personalise AI-generated content?
- What procedures do I have in place to help learners notice their authorial choice, tone, stance, and personal expression and compare them to AI output?